

MCP Quick Start Guide: Docker Desktop Setup

This guide helps beginners get started with MCPs and discover how they can improve efficiency. It's not advanced - just practical steps to get you using these powerful tools. A rising tide lifts all boats, so I'm focused on leveling up as many people as possible while encouraging MCP veterans to pay it forward.

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Prerequisites & Important Notes

Claude Plan Requirements

- **Minimum:** Claude Pro (\$20/month) - Required for multiple MCP functionality
- **Recommended:** Claude Pro Max (\$100/month) for heavy MCP usage
- **Token Awareness:** MCPs consume tokens with each tool call. The \$20 plan's 5-hour limit can be reached quickly with active MCP usage.

System Requirements

- Docker Desktop installed and running
- Claude Desktop application
- Stable internet connection

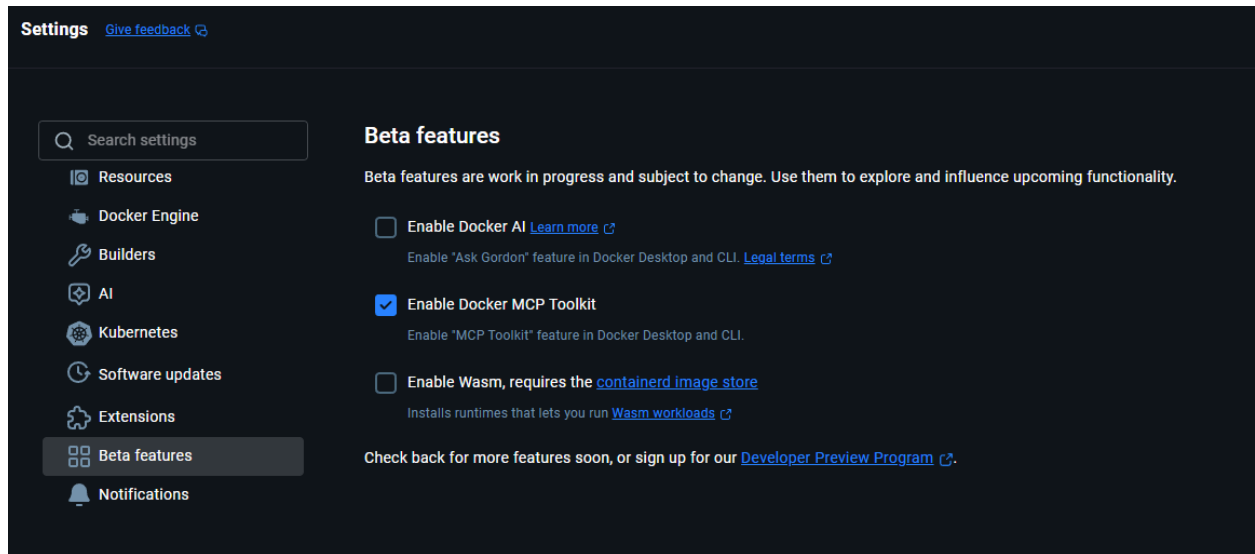
Critical Startup Sequence

IMPORTANT: Always ensure Docker Desktop is running BEFORE opening Claude Desktop. If Docker isn't running when you launch Claude, MCPs won't be available.

Part 1: Quick Setup with Docker MCP Toolkit

Recommended for beginners and users who want simple, secure MCP management

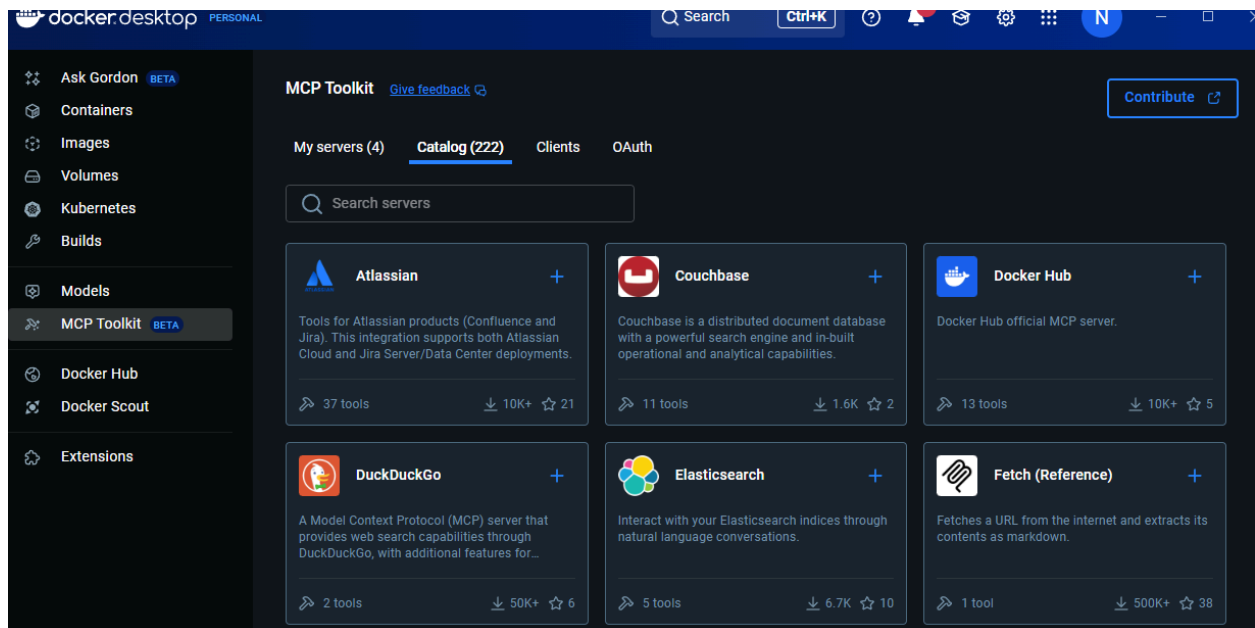
Step 1: Enable Docker MCP Toolkit



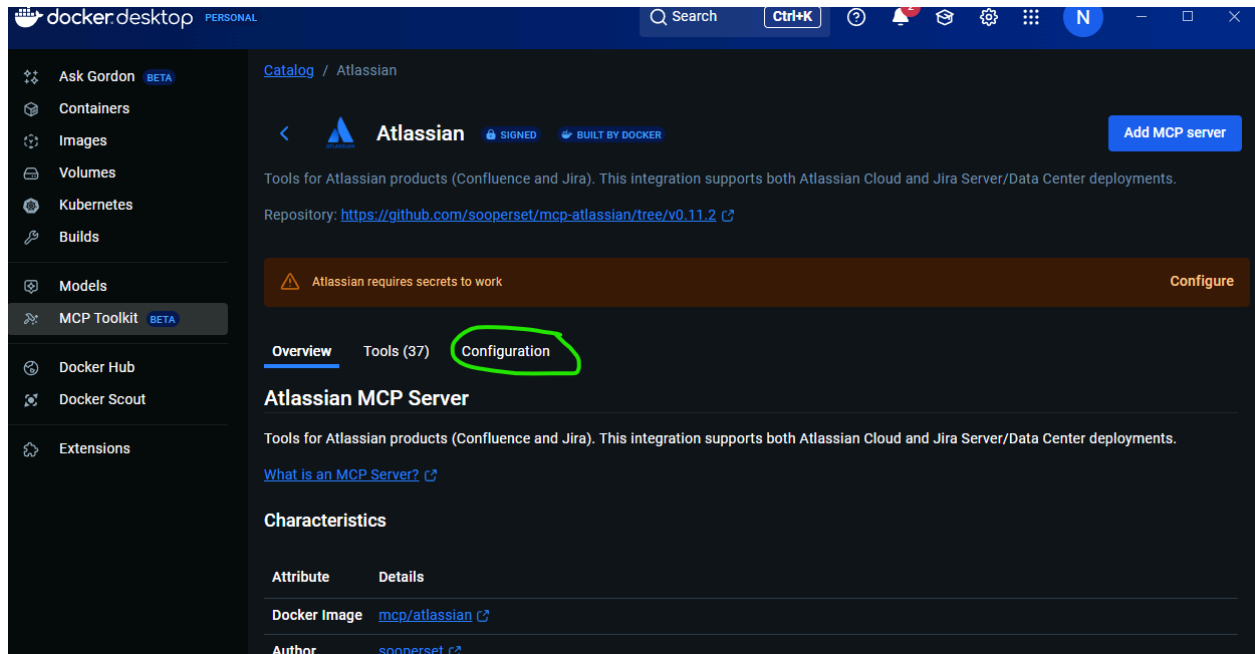
1. Open Docker Desktop
2. Navigate to **Settings** (gear icon)
3. Go to **Beta Features**
4. Enable "**Docker MCP Toolkit**"
5. Click "**Apply & Restart**"

[INSERT SCREENSHOT: Beta Features with MCP Toolkit enabled]

Step 2: Access the MCP Catalog



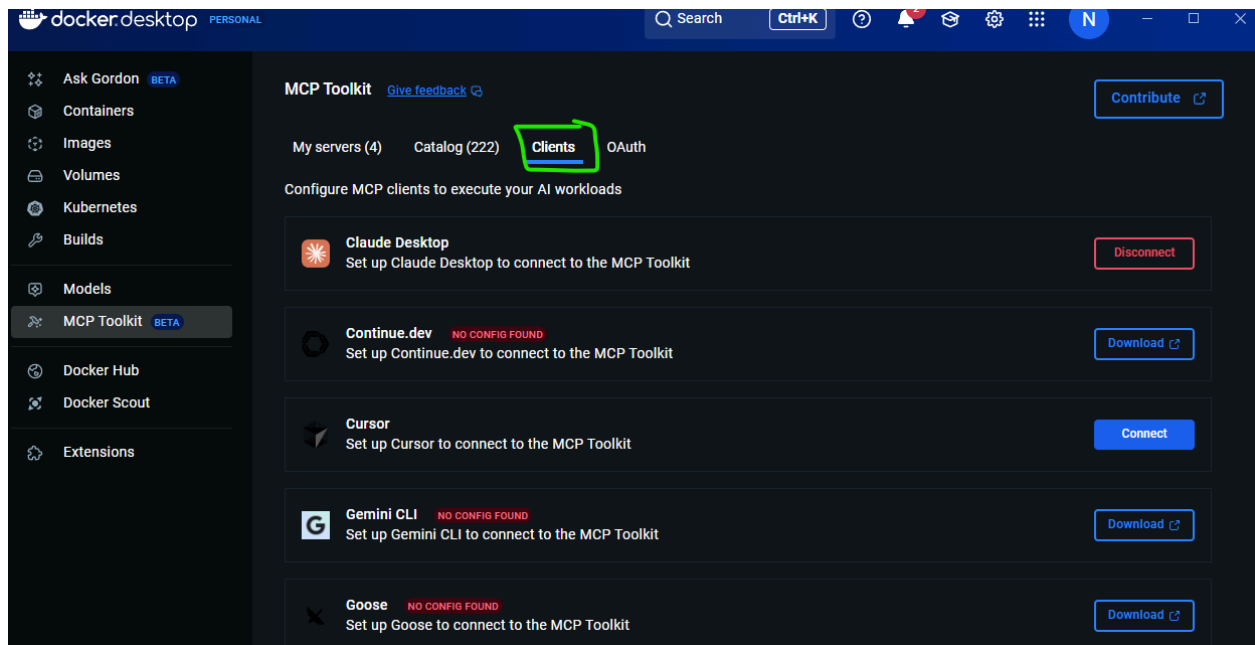
1. In Docker Desktop, look for the **MCP** section in the left sidebar
2. Click on **"Catalog"**
3. Browse available MCP servers by category:
 - Click the plus button for what you want
 - Some MCPs will require you to have a configuration set up where you add your Secrets or whatever verification needed.



Tip: Start with 1-3 servers max to avoid token overuse and interface clutter.

Step 4: Connect to Claude Desktop

1. In Docker Desktop MCP section, click **"Clients"**
2. Find **Claude Desktop** in the list
3. Click **"Connect"** next to Claude Desktop
4. Docker will automatically configure Claude's MCP settings



Step 5: Verify Setup in Claude

1. **Ensure Docker Desktop is running** before opening Claude
2. **Restart Claude Desktop completely** using proper exit procedure:
 - Go to **File > Exit** (don't just close the window)
 - Reopen Claude Desktop
3. Open a new conversation
4. Look for the **tools icon** in the message input area
5. Click the tools icon to see available MCP functions
6. You should see something like `MCP_DOCKER` which will have all of the tool functions listed out

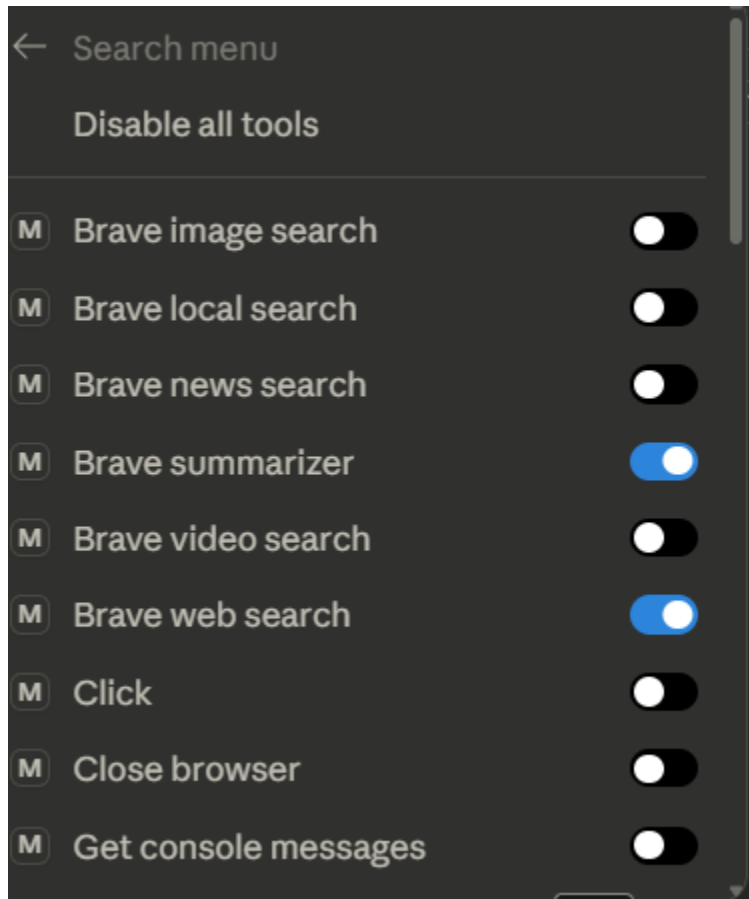
Important Restart Note

If you don't see MCPs: Always use **File > Exit** to completely close Claude Desktop, then reopen it. Simply closing the window does not fully restart the program and MCPs may not refresh properly.

Managing Your Docker MCP Setup

Function Organization (Important Note)

The Docker MCP setup displays all functions in one list rather than organizing them by server. This can become cluttered with multiple servers installed.



Enabling/Disabling Functions

1. In Claude's tools panel, you can toggle individual functions on/off
2. **Best Practice:** Only enable functions you are actively using
3. This reduces token consumption and interface clutter
4. You can re-enable functions anytime

Adding New MCPs While Claude is Running

Important: If you add a new MCP server in Docker Desktop while Claude Desktop is already open, the new MCP will NOT appear automatically. You must:

1. Go to **File > Exit** in Claude Desktop (don't just close the window)
2. Wait for Claude to completely close
3. Reopen Claude Desktop

4. The new MCP should now appear in your tools list
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Recommended First MCPs

Start Simple:

1. **Brave Search** - Web research automation

This MCP will help you learn the system without overwhelming complexity.

Part 2: Intermediate Configuration

For users who want more flexibility and direct GitHub repository access

When to Consider Intermediate Configuration

If you've outgrown the Docker MCP Toolkit and want more flexibility with GitHub repositories or custom configurations, you can manually configure MCPs using Claude Desktop's configuration file.

Accessing the Configuration File: [Resource on how](#)

1. Open Claude Desktop
2. Go to **File > Settings**
3. Click on **Developer**
4. Click **"Edit Config"**

This will open Claude's MCP configuration file, which will likely be empty if you've never modified it manually.

Benefits of Manual Configuration

- **More Control:** Fine-tune specific MCP settings
- **GitHub Integration:** Direct access to any public MCP repository
- **Custom Configurations:** Advanced parameter settings

When to Stick with Docker Toolkit

- **Beginners:** Easier setup and management
 - **Security Focus:** Isolated, containerized execution
 - **Simple Needs:** Basic MCP functionality is sufficient
 - **Less Technical:** Prefer GUI over configuration files
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Token Management Tips

Monitor Usage Carefully

- **Check Usage:** Monitor your Claude usage regularly in the app
- **Selective Activation:** Only turn on MCPs for specific projects/tasks
- **Upgrade When Needed:** Heavy MCP users benefit from the \$100 plan

High Token Usage

- Disable unused MCP functions
 - Use MCPs strategically, not for every task
 - Consider upgrading to Claude Pro Max (\$100)
 - Monitor usage in Claude settings
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Security Best Practices

Evaluate Before Installing

- Check MCP server ratings on Glama.ai
- Review GitHub repository (stars, commits, contributors)
- Read community feedback and reviews
- Use JeredBlu's MCP security evaluation system

API Key Management

- Store API keys securely in Docker secrets
 - Never hardcode keys in configurations
 - Regularly rotate sensitive credentials
 - Monitor API usage for unusual activity
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Support & Resources

Official Documentation: [Docker MCP Docs](#)

MCP Discovery:

- GitHub: [modelcontextprotocol/servers](#)
- Community: [awesome-mcp-servers](#)
- Rated: [Glama.ai MCP Directory](#)

Security: [JeredBlu's MCP Evaluator](#)

His [video](#) explaining it

Learning Resources:

- **NetworkChuck Tutorial:** [Complete MCP setup guide](#)
- **Mark Kachef Tutorial:** [Custom MCP development](#)
- **Maximizing Claude Riley Brown:** [MCP setup](#)